

Active Directory Home Folders

Setup and Configuration Guide

Secure, per-user network home drive (H:) mapping for domain clients

Document ID	AD-SOP-005
Scope	Windows Server (AD DS) domain environments, Windows 10/11 clients
Owner	IT Specialist — Systems / Infrastructure
Prerequisites	Domain Admin or delegated OU rights; access to ADUC and the file server
Related SOPs	AD-SOP-004 (Roaming Profiles), Onboarding/Offboarding SOP, File Server ACL Standards

Overview

This guide documents the configuration of secure, automated Home Folders (Home Drive, mapped as H:) for Active Directory user accounts. It covers share provisioning, NTFS permission hardening for per-user isolation, linking the home folder path in AD, and a verification procedure on a client machine.

A home folder gives each user a private, network-based storage location that is automatically mapped to a drive letter at logon, independent of which workstation they use. As with roaming profiles, the share holds personal data for every domain user, so correct permissioning is essential — a misconfigured ACL can expose one user's files to another.

Step 1 — Create the Share and Configure Network Share Permissions

Create a hidden root directory on the file server to hold every user's individual home folder:

- Folder Path: C:\AD-shares\HomePath\$
- Advanced Sharing Name: HomePath\$

Use Advanced Sharing rather than the simple sharing wizard, and configure the following share permissions:

Principal	Share Permission	Notes
Authenticated Users	Full Control	Allows any domain user to reach the share; real access control is enforced at the NTFS layer below.
Administrators	Full Control	Standard admin access for management and recovery.
Users (SERVER\Users)	Removed	The default broad-access group is removed to prevent general browsing of the share.

Step 2 — Configure Advanced NTFS Security Permissions

This is the step that enforces per-user privacy. Navigate to the Security tab of the share's root folder, open Advanced, and select Disable Inheritance → "Convert inherited permissions into explicit permissions" so the folder's ACL is isolated from its parent. Configure the following explicit entries:

Principal	Access / Permissions	Applies To	Purpose
SYSTEM	Full Control	This folder, subfolders and files	Required by the OS to manage home folder files.
Administrators	Full Control	This folder, subfolders and files	Allows IT to manage/restore home folders when needed.
CREATOR OWNER	Full Control	Subfolders and files only	Grants the folder owner full rights to their own subfolder only, once created.
Authenticated Users	Read & execute, List folder contents, Read, Write	This folder only	Lets any domain user create their own home folder at first logon. Isolation from other users' folders comes from disabled inheritance + explicit ACEs, not from this entry.
Users (SERVER\Users)	Removed	N/A	The default broad-access group is removed so it cannot override the explicit ACEs above.

NOTE: Remove the default 'Users (SERVER\Users)' group entirely from the ACL. Leaving it in place is the most common cause of users being able to browse each other's home folders.

Step 3 — Link the Home Folder in Active Directory

Open Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC), select the target user, open Properties → Profile tab, and configure the Home Folder section:

1. Select the Connect radio button.
2. From the drive-letter drop-down, choose the desired network letter: H:
3. In the To: field, type the exact UNC path using the username variable:

```
\\server\lab\HomePath$\%username%
```

4. Click Apply.

On Apply, AD automatically resolves %username% to the user's actual sAMAccountName (e.g. j.acebuche), so the same path string can be applied in bulk across many accounts via ADUC multi-select or PowerShell.

Step 4 — Test and Verify

1. Log in as the target user (e.g. j.acebuche) on a computer joined to the domain.
2. Open This PC / File Explorer. A new network location drive (H:) should be visible.
3. Save a test file inside Drive H:. It should be stored automatically on the server.
4. On the server, confirm the file appears inside the user's folder under C:\AD-shares\HomePath\$.
5. As with roaming profiles, attempt to open another user's home folder using an account that is not the owner or an Administrator with standing access. A permission-denied result confirms isolation is working as intended.

Additional Considerations

- **Storage quotas:** Set storage quotas per user via File Server Resource Manager (FSRM) to prevent uncontrolled growth of the HomePath\$ share.

- **Home folder vs. Folder Redirection:** Home folders map a drive letter and are best suited to simple personal storage. For redirecting specific folders (Desktop, Documents, Pictures) with more granular policy control, use Folder Redirection via Group Policy instead of, or alongside, home folders.
- **Offline access:** If users work with large files over VPN or slow links, expect slower access to Drive H: since it is a live network path, not a synced local cache (unlike Offline Files/Folder Redirection with caching enabled).
- **Environment variables:** Home folder paths set here are also used automatically by legacy applications and command-line tools that reference %HOMESHARE% and %HOMEPATH%, so verify any in-house scripts relying on these variables after rollout.
- **Backup scope:** Confirm the HomePath\$ share is included in the file server's backup job — home folder loss without a backup means full loss of user file storage.

Revision History

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2026-09-02	Initial SOP created from lab-tested configuration (SERVERLAB environment).